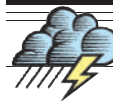


The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

RE V1 V2 V3 V4



T-storms 80/69 • Tomorrow: A shower 82/68 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 25, 2025 • \$4

FEMA staff recount a struggle to reach chief

Leader was inaccessible for about 24 hours after Texas flood, officials say

BY BRIANNA SACKS

On a Friday morning in July, shortly after deadly Independence Day floods swept through parts of Texas Hill Country packed with camps full of young children, the Federal Emergency Management Agency scrambled to coordinate a response. The next afternoon, teams readied search-and-rescue crews, imagery and other emergency equipment. Then their hustling hit a roadblock.

They couldn't reach a key U.S. official needed to deploy the resources, one required by law to be accessible during emergencies: FEMA's acting administrator, David Richardson.

Just a few weeks earlier, his boss, Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem, instituted a policy requiring her approval for any expenditure over \$100,000. That meant, in order to deploy resources to Texas, FEMA officials needed Richardson to get those requests in front of Noem — fast.

But for about 24 hours in the early aftermath of one of the nation's deadliest flash-flooding events in decades, key staff members could not reach FEMA's top official, according to eight current and former officials with knowledge of the situation who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they said they feared retaliation. The agency's

SEE FEMA ON A6



EFREM LUKATSKY/AP

Ukrainian troops bow their heads in respect to a soldier killed in the war as the hearse carrying his body drives by on Wednesday.

Russia dismisses Trump's pivot to Kyiv

This article is by Siobhán O'Grady, Francesca Ebel, Natalia Abbakumova, Catherine Belton and Steve Hendrix

'He will come back,' officials insist following abrupt rhetoric change

and a half years."

KYIV — President Donald Trump's abrupt change in rhetoric on Ukraine, in which he declared it could retake all its territory with help from NATO, was warmly welcomed by Kyiv and quickly dismissed Wednesday by Moscow, particularly his calling the Russian military "a paper tiger" that had been "fighting aimlessly for three

The few early reactions trickling out of Moscow on Wednesday demonstrated how deeply Trump's unexpectedly friendly appearance in New York alongside Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky on the sidelines

of the U.N. General Assembly vexed the Kremlin, which just weeks ago was gloating over Russian President Vladimir Putin's warm reception in Alaska.

"Russia is in no way a tiger. Still, Russia is more compared with a bear. There are no paper bears," Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said to local radio on Wednesday.

Peskov also suggested the motivation behind Trump's push to halt European purchases of Russian oil and gas — which are helping fund Russia's

war machine — is tied to his desire to boost American sales.

At a later briefing with reporters, Peskov pushed back on Trump's comments that the war is "aimless," while still thanking Trump for his willingness to promote peace — and warning that Ukraine was in a dire position.

Kyiv is "trying to demonstrate to their sponsors in Europe and their handlers that they can fight, but they should not forget that with each passing day when

SEE RUSSIA ON A12

ICE facility in Dallas is targeted in fatal shooting

BY ARELIS R. HERNÁNDEZ, MARÍA LUISA PAÚL, DAVID NAKAMURA AND HOLLY BAILEY

DALLAS — A gunman opened fire on an Immigration and Customs Enforcement facility in Dallas early Wednesday, killing a detainee and critically wounding two others before fatally shooting himself in what authorities called a "targeted" act of violence against immigration enforcement agents.

The suspected shooter was identified late Wednesday as Joshua Jahn, 29, according to four people briefed on the investigation who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to publicly discuss the matter.

No law enforcement officers were injured in the attack, and investigators had not yet identified a clear motive. But President Donald Trump and others in his administration quickly seized on the incident as politically motivated violence.

Unspent ammunition recovered at the scene had been marked with the phrase "ANTI-ICE." FBI Director Kash Patel, who shared an image of the shell casing on social media, described it as evidence the shooter had acted with an "ideological motive."

Trump and others appeared to cast law enforcement as the victims of the Dallas attack, even

SEE ICE ON A4



TOM BRENNER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Curtains for dancing statue

The National Park Service removed a 12-foot-tall display of President Donald Trump and Jeffrey Epstein holding hands from the National Mall, one day after it was placed. **Story, B13**

AI tool promises safety, but students call it a spy

BY DANIEL WU

Students at a Kansas high school sometimes worry as they write class presentations or emails to their teachers. They stop and consider their words. They ask each other: "Will this get Gaggled?"

Anything students at Lawrence High write or upload to their school accounts can get "Gaggled" — flagged by Gaggle Safety Management, a digital safety tool the Lawrence, Kansas, high school purchased in 2023. Gaggle uses artificial intelligence to scan student documents and emails for signs of unsafe behavior, such as substance abuse or threats of violence or self-harm, which it deletes or reports to school staff.

Students say it's doing much more than that. Since Gaggle came online in Lawrence, it has deleted part of an art student's portfolio — a photo of girls wear-

ing tank tops — after mistakenly flagging it as child pornography. Another student was questioned by administrators after writing that they were "gonna die" because they ran a fitness test wearing Crocs shoes.

When Suzana Kennedy, 19, emailed a records request to the school last year for a report of student material flagged by Gaggle, Gaggle blocked her attempt to investigate it, she said. The system flagged and intercepted the school's response containing the records. Kennedy never received the reply.

This is what some students say life in high school is like under the watch of an AI-powered safety tool like Gaggle, which boasts partnerships with around 1,500 school districts across the country. The Illinois-based company advertises its round-the-clock monitoring as a bulwark against a litany of threats to today's

SEE AI ON A14

She posted about Kirk. Now her job is on the line.

BY PATRICK MARLEY AND YVONNE WINGETT SANCHEZ

ELLSWORTH, WIS. — After a long day teaching high school algebra in this small town near the Mississippi River, Krista Lesiecki settled into her favorite recliner to catch up on news about the death of Charlie Kirk. She quickly grew exasperated.

Why were so many people

glossing over his comments questioning whether Black pilots were qualified and saying some gun deaths were "worth" accepting in exchange for Second Amendment rights, she wondered. She tapped out a Facebook post saying that Kirk "spewed hate" and that those who agreed with his views on guns "can't be upset that he died."

Lesiecki's post caught the attention of her bosses, angered people in town and, within days, ricocheted across the internet as a congressman threatened to withdraw federal funding from the community "unless this is rectified." School officials suspended her with pay, and their lawyer questioned her about her character, her work history and her post about Kirk, according to

Lesiecki's attorney.

Now, Lesiecki said, she is nervously waiting to see if she will be fired or otherwise disciplined. The school's superintendent declined to comment.

"People are upset that people wanted to silence Charlie Kirk, but they're not upset that I'm being silenced," Lesiecki, 54, said in an interview. "I'm not proud of

SEE KIRK ON A18



RANDY HOLMES/DISNEY/AP

Back on the air

Jimmy Kimmel returned to TV after controversy over comments. **B1**

IN THE NEWS

Revamp of foreign aid The White House plans to shift nearly \$2 billion toward "America First" priorities, the latest challenge to Congress's spending authority. **A2**

New leadership The Nationals were finalizing a deal with Paul Toboni of the Boston Red Sox to take over their baseball operations. **B7**

THE NATION

In a first, an experimental treatment for Huntington's slowed the disease's progression. **A4**
A new poll signals a shift in Americans' confidence in higher education. **A5**

THE WORLD

A super typhoon battered the Philippines, killed 17 in Taiwan and closed Hong Kong. **A8**
Israel's isolation is mounting internationally, but the impact thus far remains limited. **A9**

THE ECONOMY

Wall Street investors are buying up claims to possible tariff refunds, betting Trump's signature policy will fail at the Supreme Court. **A13**
Disney, still grappling with a backlash after Jimmy Kimmel's sidelining, will raise streaming service prices. **A13**

STYLE

Gucci's new designer, Demna, makes his Milan debut not on the runway, but with a short-film premiere. **B1**

SPORTS

As Jayden Daniels gets healthier, the Commanders quarterback's top target is dealing with an injury. **B7**

METRO

The family of a victim of the midair collision near National Airport is suing American Airlines and a subsidiary. **B13**

LOCAL LIVING

The blend of clothing fibers, dead skin, soil, pollen and dander we call dust is sneaky, but it's also predictable.

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